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Living With the Misprint

A season-end proofread audit of community theatre playbill misprints against the corrections formally requested

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The problem

Every participating company prints a correction-request address in its season programme, and almost nobody writes to it. Does that channel's tally describe a season's misprints, or only the ones judged worth a form?

Objectives

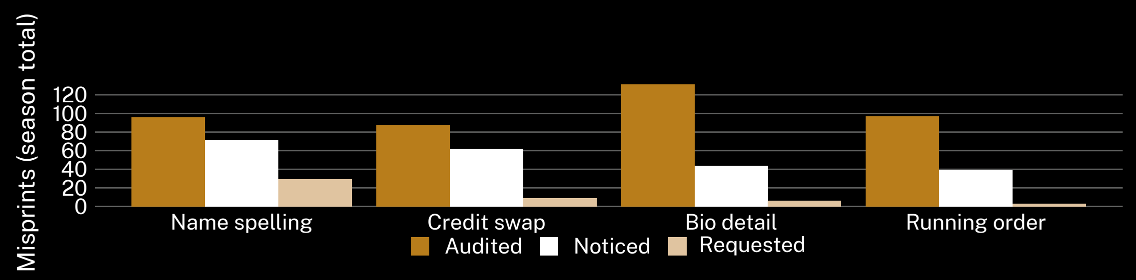
- Estimate a season's true playbill misprint rate by independent audit.
- Quantify the shortfall between misprints found and corrections filed.
- Test whether filing rate varies by category at equal rates of noticing.

Approach

- 9 community theatre companies · 34 programme printings · one full 2025 season · two blind proofreaders per printing.
- Every misprint coded to four categories against the production's own cast and crew records; two-reader agreement 0.81, disagreements settled by a third reader.
- Correction-request logs supplied in full; a post-season recall survey of 218 cast and crew fielded before any audit result was returned. Category definitions were registered with each company before opening night and none were amended mid-season.

What we found

Formal requests recover roughly one misprint in nine. The shortfall is not uniform: at comparable rates of noticing, a misspelled personal name is filed at close to three times the rate of a swapped technical credit.



Misprints across the nine companies' 2025 seasons (34 programme printings): 412 found by independent audit, 216 recalled as noticed, 47 formally requested. Misspelled personal names supply 23% of audited misprints and 62% of every request filed.

Implications

Results suggest a correction-request channel registers offence rather than error, and unevenly by category: a company reading its request tally as a print-quality measure understates its own season by close to an order of magnitude. Next: whether an audit returned to a company moves its next request rate, or only its proofreading.

Further reading

1. Classen, D. C., Resar, R., Griffin, F., et al. (2011). "Global Trigger Tool" shows that adverse events in hospitals may be ten times greater than previously measured. *Health Affairs*, 30(4), 581–589. doi:10.1377/hlthaff.2011.0190
2. Sari, A. B.-A., Sheldon, T. A., Cracknell, A., & Turnbull, A. (2007). Sensitivity of routine system for reporting patient safety incidents in an NHS hospital: retrospective patient case note review. *BMJ*, 334(7584), 79. doi:10.1136/bmj.39031.507153.AE
3. Evans, S. M., Berry, J. G., Smith, B. J., et al. (2006). Attitudes and barriers to incident reporting: a collaborative hospital study. *Quality and Safety in Health Care*, 15(1), 39–43. doi:10.1136/qshc.2004.012559
4. Barach, P., & Small, S. D. (2000). Reporting and preventing medical mishaps: lessons from non-medical near miss reporting systems. *BMJ*, 320(7237), 759–763. doi:10.1136/bmj.320.7237.759
5. Healy, A. F. (1976). Detection errors on the word *the*: Evidence for reading units larger than letters. *Journal of Experimental Psychology: Human Perception and Performance*, 2(2), 235–242. doi:10.1037/0096-1523.2.2.235
6. Hanke, M., & Sabel, R. (2026). One Tile, Five Categories: A Coding Taxonomy of Campus Suggestion-Box Submissions Against What the Engagement Pulse Tile Carries Forward. *Slop University technical report.* doi:10.5555/slop.tlmg6a

Programmes audited from archived print copies with each company's consent; request logs de-identified.

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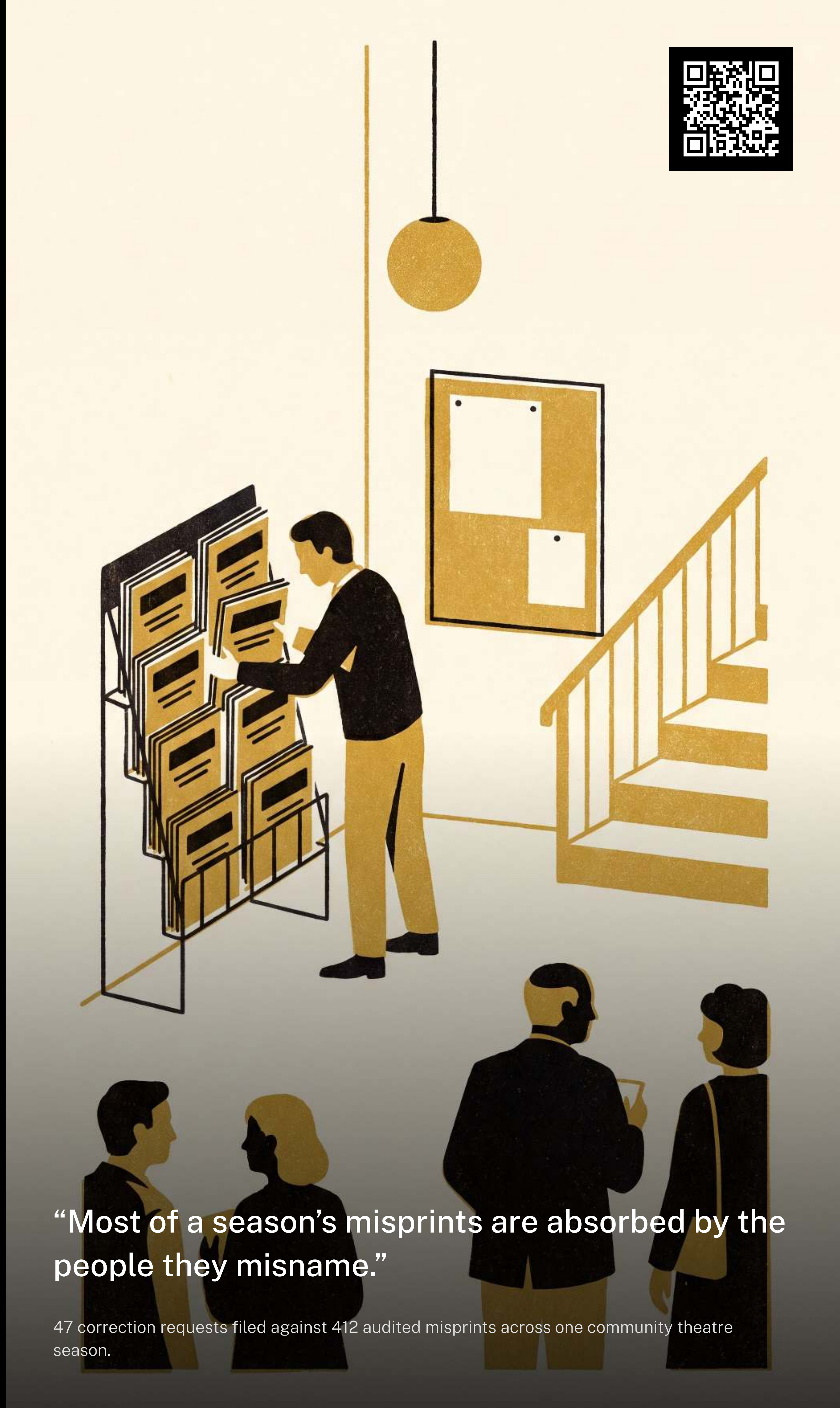

"Most of a season's misprints are absorbed by the people they misname."

47 correction requests filed against 412 audited misprints across one community theatre season.